

PRACTICAL GUIDE

Whisper for transcription

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READ THIS FIRST

Whisper produces an **automatic transcript**, but every transcript must be proofread and corrected before it is used as research data.

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1 About this guide

This guide describes, step by step, how to use Whisper to transcribe audio recordings automatically in the lab. It covers the whole workflow: preparing the project and the audio files, running the transcription, monitoring it, then retrieving and checking the transcripts.

It is written for anyone who records interviews and needs a first transcript, **intended to be proofread and corrected as required**. No programming experience is needed: every command is given ready to copy.

TIME NEEDED	WHERE	WHAT YOU GET
≈ 5 min to set up	The lab transcription workstation — room A4.340	One text file per recording, to proofread and correct

2 Before you start

2.1 — Access checks

- 01** You have contacted Laurent Ott to obtain an account allowing you to book the workstation at: https://scalab-apps.univ-lille.fr/grr/month_all.php?area=1&day=16&year=2026&month=09 located in room A4.340.
- 02** Your recordings are saved on a USB stick.

3 The workflow at a glance

- 01 Prepare the audio files**
Copy the recordings onto the workstation. §4
 - 02 Set up the project folder**
One folder per project, with *Audio* and *Transcripts*. §5
 - 03 Run the transcription**
Open Spyder, move into the folder, run the code. §6
 - 04 Monitor progress**
The console prints segments as it goes; do not close it. §7
 - 05 Retrieve the transcripts**
Open the output folder, check the start and end of the text. §8
 - 06 Proofread and correct**
Mandatory before analysis: proper nouns, technical terms, overlapping speech. §8.3
-

4 Preparing the recordings

Transcript quality depends directly on recording quality. Clean audio cuts proofreading time sharply.

IF POSSIBLE

Place the microphone within a metre of the speakers
Limit background noise (ventilation, corridor)
Run a 20-second test before the interview

AVOID

Recording with a laptop's built-in microphone
Highly reverberant rooms

4.1 — Accepted formats and conversion

Whisper reads most common formats through ffmpeg: `.wav .mp3 .m4a .flac .ogg .mp4 .mov`, and so on.

5

Organising project folders

One folder per project, always the same structure. That is what lets you run the same code from one project to the next, changing nothing but the folder name.

```
~/Transcripts/  
├─ Project_01/  
│   ├─ Audio/           ← recordings to transcribe  
│   └─ Transcripts/      ← Whisper output  
├─ Project_02/  
│   ├─ Audio/  
│   └─ Transcripts/  
│       └─ Log.csv  
└─ Project_03/  
    └─ ...
```

[SCREENSHOT] The project folder tree in File Explorer

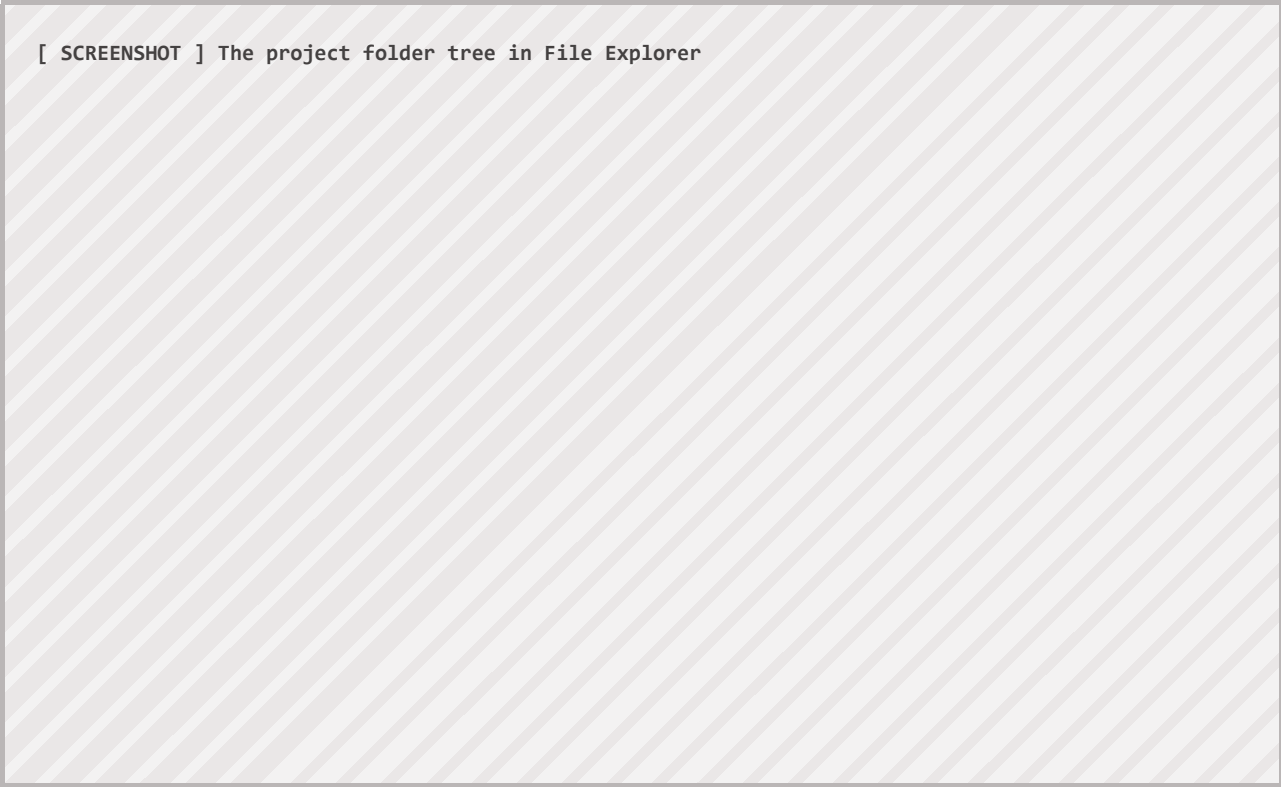


Fig. 1 – placeholder for the folder-organisation screenshot.

6 Running the transcription

6.1 — Opening Spyder

[SCREENSHOT] Opening Spyder and the working window

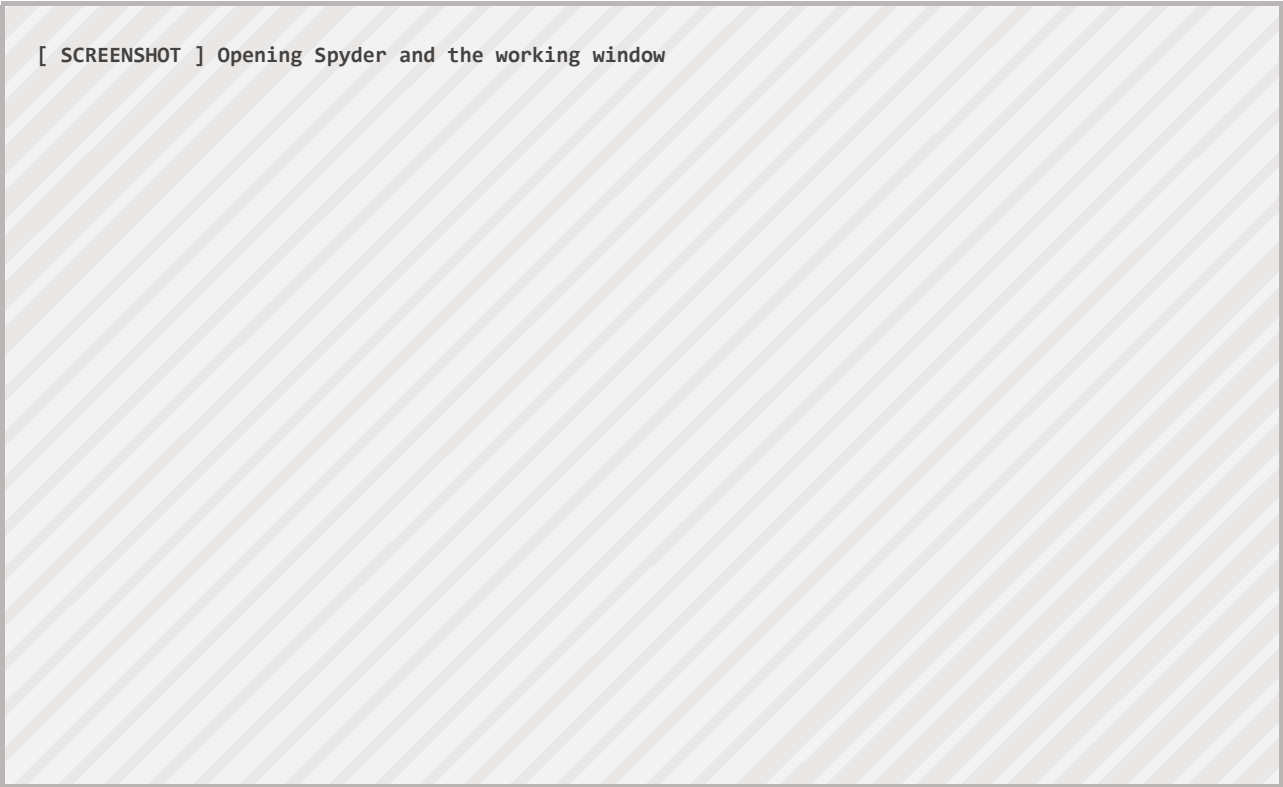
A large rectangular area with a light gray background and diagonal gray lines, serving as a placeholder for a screenshot.

Fig. 2 — placeholder for the Spyder launch screenshot.

6.2 — Transcribing a single file

[SCREENSHOT] The code to run for a single file

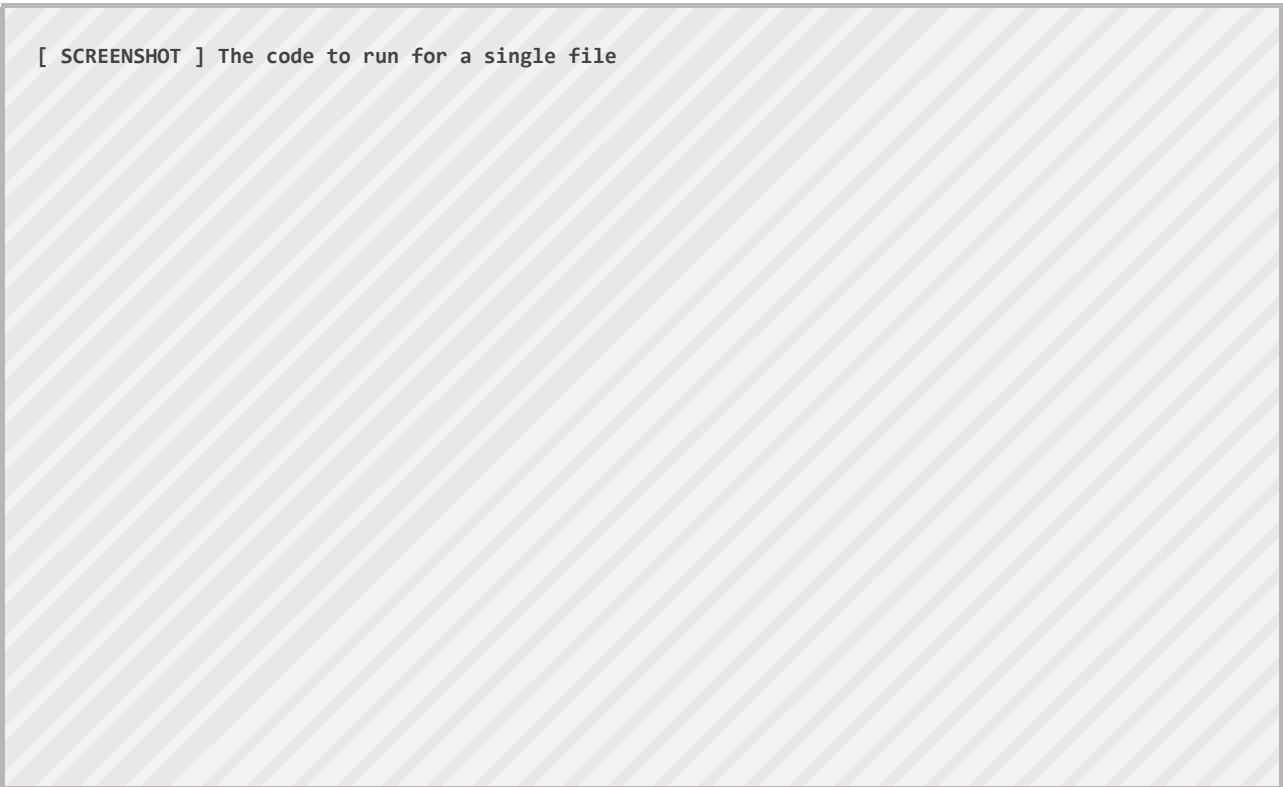
A large rectangular area with a light gray background and diagonal gray lines, serving as a placeholder for a screenshot.

Fig. 3 — placeholder for the transcription script screenshot.

6.3 — Transcribing every file in a project

[SCREENSHOT] The code adapted to processing a whole folder

A large rectangular area with a light gray background and diagonal gray lines, serving as a placeholder for a screenshot.

Fig. 4 — placeholder for the batch script screenshot.

[SCREENSHOT] The console at launch — full command and first lines of output

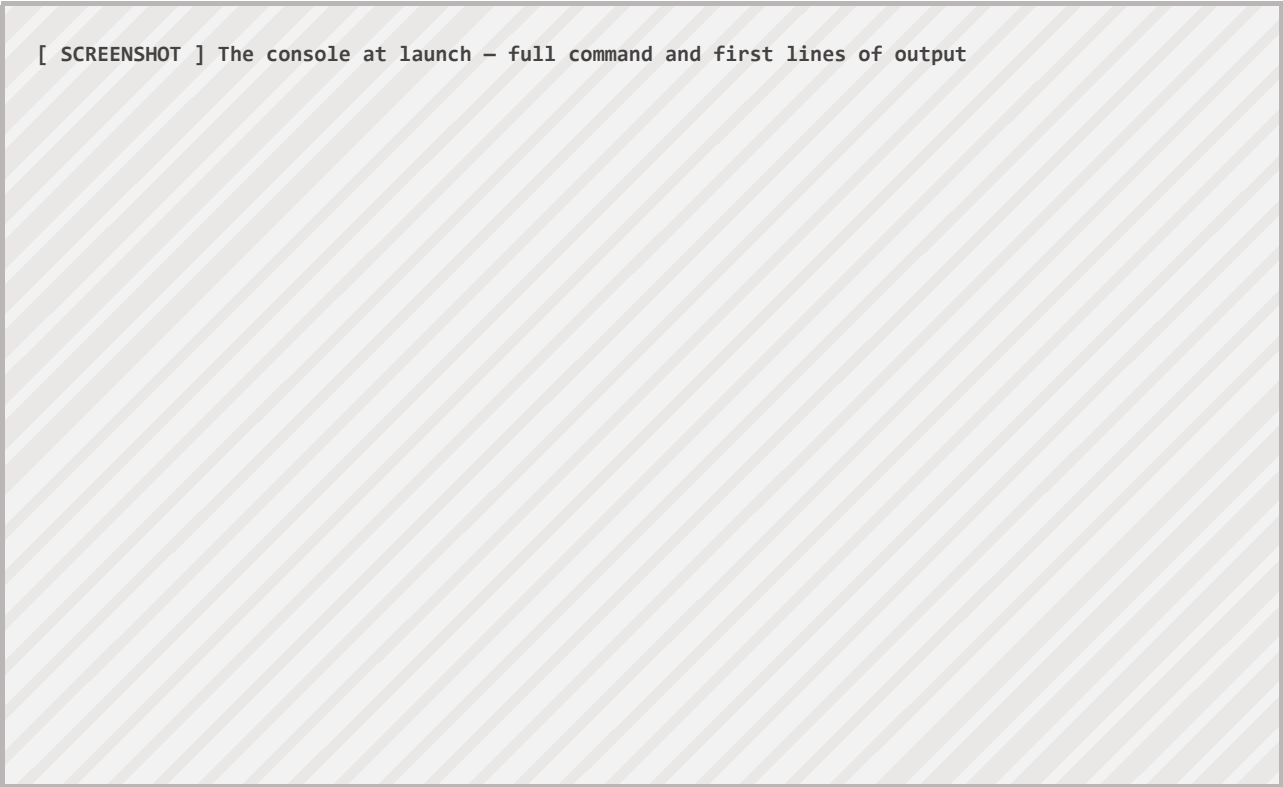
A large rectangular area with a light gray background and diagonal gray lines, serving as a placeholder for a screenshot.

Fig. 5 — placeholder, to be replaced with a screenshot from workstation A4.340.

7 Monitoring progress

WHILE IT RUNS

Do not close the console and do not let the workstation go to sleep.

If the process seems stuck, in this order:

- 01 Wait a few minutes: a long silence in the audio slows the model down considerably.
- 02 Read the last line in the console: an error message there is almost always explicit.
- 03 Check that the audio file opens normally in a player.
- 04 Check the folder path and the exact spelling of the file name.
- 05 Stop with Ctrl + C, then rerun on a single file to isolate the problem.

8 Retrieving and checking the transcript

8.1 — Where the files are

In the folder that holds your original audio recordings.

8.2 — Quick check (two minutes per file)

- 01 The file exists and its name matches the audio.
- 02 The text is readable and in the expected language.
- 03 The opening lines match the real start of the interview.
- 04 The end is not cut off, and no sentence repeats in a loop.

8.3 — Proofreading and correction

Proofreading is essential in order to:

- anonymise names of people and places
- check medical or scientific terminology
- acronyms and abbreviations.
- inaudible phrases rendered as an approximation
- overlapping speech
- background noise read as words
- unmarked speaker changes

EXAMPLES

[inaudible 00:12:31] — unintelligible passage, with the timestamp from the .srt

I: / P: — interviewer / participant, added during proofreading

[laughs], [silence] — non-verbal elements kept by the protocol

<P012> — systematic pseudonymisation of proper nouns before analysis

9 Processing several files and projects

You can run several transcriptions at once simply by dropping all the interviews you want into the folder. Starting the transcription will then process every file in that folder automatically. One point to watch: if the formats differ, Whisper will only transcribe the files matching the format stated in the code — you will have to repeat the operation, changing the format name each time.

10 References

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A question, an error not listed here, a command worth adding? Report it for the next version of this guide.

END OF GUIDE